Sukhbir: The CM as CEO

Sukhbir Badal is a picture of confidence. As his cream-coloured Toyota Land Cruiser speeds down a gleaming four-laned state highway to Mandi Gobindgarh, once the steel town of Punjab, the 59-year-old, seated in front, turns around to say, "Just look at the quality of roads—this is what I got done in the 10 years that we were in power. What Punjab needs is a strong, decisive and passionate chief minister like me—not comedians." Sukhbir is unapologetic about his vast business interests that include hotels, transport vehicles and TV channels, saying that he does not run these directly and is only a promoter. "A person who runs a successful business can also successfully run a state," he says. "The CM should be the CEO of the state—he must have vision and know how to get people to implement it."

The younger Badal is now his own boss and, for the first time in an assembly election, in full control of SAD. He has come out from the shadow of his father, Parkash Singh Badal, who has had a record five terms as chief minister and is still contesting, at the age of 94. Sukhbir says his father taught him how to solve complex problems with patience, adding, "It is experience you cannot gain anywhere else." He shrugs off criticism about the Akali legacy devolving into a dynastic monopoly—his wife, Harsimrat Kaur, was a Union minister; her brother, Bikram Singh Majithia is a party strongman-MLA. He says he had to work hard to win the party's confidence and demonstrate his organisational capabilities. After decades, SAD is fighting without the BJP as an ally—having walked out of the Union cabinet in a bid to minimise damage to the party by the taint of association after the farm laws. Amarinder believes that act of protest alone does not absolve the Akali Dal of the blame and that Punjab farmers are still upset with them. The former CM points out that issues like the desecration of sacred Sikh texts and Punjab's drug mafias—part of the reasons why SAD was defeated by the Congress in 2017—are still relevant in this election.

Sukhbir counters this with the fact that, despite being in power for four and a half years, Amarinder failed to establish any conspiracy behind the alleged desecrations or to back up the allegations of Majithia being involved in drug trafficking. He is contemptuous of the alliance Amarinder's PLC has forged with the BJP, saying, "Zero plus zero equals zero." He has no regrets about the SAD parting ways with the BJP saying, "In 2017, we fought 94 seats and the BJP only 23. Out of our 94 seats, in about 60, they contributed zero votes to us." Instead, SAD has tied up with the BSP—"I made one call to Mayawati and she agreed"—and believes it would bring a minimum of 5,000 votes in some areas and "around 30,000 votes per constituency in Doaba". The BSP in Punjab has cadre among Dalit Sikhs too, many with panthic leanings. They see going with the Akalis as

AT HIS RALLIES, SUKHBIR IS PLAYING UP THE FACT THAT THE SHIROMANI AKALI DAL IS THE ONLY TRUE PUNJABI PARTY



SHIROMANI AKALI DAL

CM candidate
SUKHBIR SINGH BADAL, 59

Alliance partner
Bahujan Samaj Party

STRENGTHS

- Strong organisational structure
- Its campaign got off to an early start
- Assured support of Jat Sikhs
- Badal seen as a doer with a vision for Punjab's development

CHALLENGES

- Party still dogged by the emotive sacrilege and drug issues
- Remains dominated by a single family, the Badals
- Has lost some caste Hindu support following its split with BJP
- Alliance with BSP has not fetched much traction yet